Making a Splash: The Salience of Liquid Variation among Boston Spanish speakers

In sociolinguistics, studying linguistic variables has been crucial for understanding language variation. While previous research focused on individual variables, recent advancements highlight the importance of exploring the relationships between multiple variables within a speech community [4, 3, 2]. This paper presents preliminary findings from a study on *liquid variation* in Spanish dialectal variation, examining its relationship with five other variables: Filled Pauses, Subject Personal Pronouns, SPP placement, general subject placement, and coda /s/.

The study investigates the covariation and coherence of these variables and considers the influence of salience on their usage. Building upon previous research, the study emphasizes the inclusion of multiple salient variables in sociolinguistic studies. [1] & [2] found covariation among low-salience features while the salient feature, coda /s/, remained independent. This study expands the investigation to include liquid variation.

Liquid variation and *coda /s/* are Labovian stereotypes, representing highly socially aware features with systematic variation, distinct variants, phonetic differences, and a role in maintaining phonological contrast. *Liquid variation*, including laterals and rhotics, is the main focus, exploring its distribution and intra-linguistic factors influencing its usage. The study also aims to determine whether there is covariation between *liquid variation*n and the other variables.

This study addresses the question of whether non-salient and salient features exhibit different patterns. The prediction is that low salience features show contact-induced structural convergence, while salient features are treated differently by speakers, with their indexical potential amplified by saliency.

My objectives include examining distribution patterns and intra-linguistic factors of *liquid variation* among Spanish speakers in the Greater Boston Area, as well as investigating its potential covariation with the other five variables. This study contributes to understanding variable linguistic coherence within Spanish dialectal variation, particularly in the context of dialectal and linguistic contact.

For the *liquid variation*, the preliminary results in Figure 1 demonstrate a consistent tendency for dialectal persistence, where child arrivals (Donaldo & Priscila) closely mirror the linguistic characteristics of the adults arrivals (David & Pascal). This is consistent to [2]'s findings for coda /s/ in that the structural pressure of convergence with English, where systematic liquid neutralization is not a generalized feature of the phonology, doesn't hold salient features. In other words, these features demonstrate a tendency towards persistence rather than convergence in the context of dialectal and linguistic contact driven by their saliency. These results emphasize the importance of considering salience and covariation in sociolinguistic research to advance our understanding of variable linguistic coherence in dialectal and linguistic contact contexts.

Word Count:459

[1] D. Erker. "Contact, Co-Variation, and Sociolinguistic Salience: What Mister Rogers Knows about Language Change". In: *University of Pennsylvania Working Papers in Linguistics (Selected Papers from NWAV45)* 23.2 (2017). **[2]** D. Erker. "How social salience can illuminate the outcomes of linguistic contact". In: *The Coherence of Linguistic Communities*. Ed. by K. V. Beaman and G. R. Guy. 1st. New York: Routledge, 2022. Chap. 8. **[3]** D. Erker and R. Otheguy. "Contact and coherence: Dialectal leveling and structural convergence in NYC Spanish". English. In: *Lingua* 172-173 (2016). **[4]** G. R. Guy and F. Hinskens. "Linguistic coherence: Systems, repertoires and speech communities". In: *Lingua* 172-173 (2016).

Figures

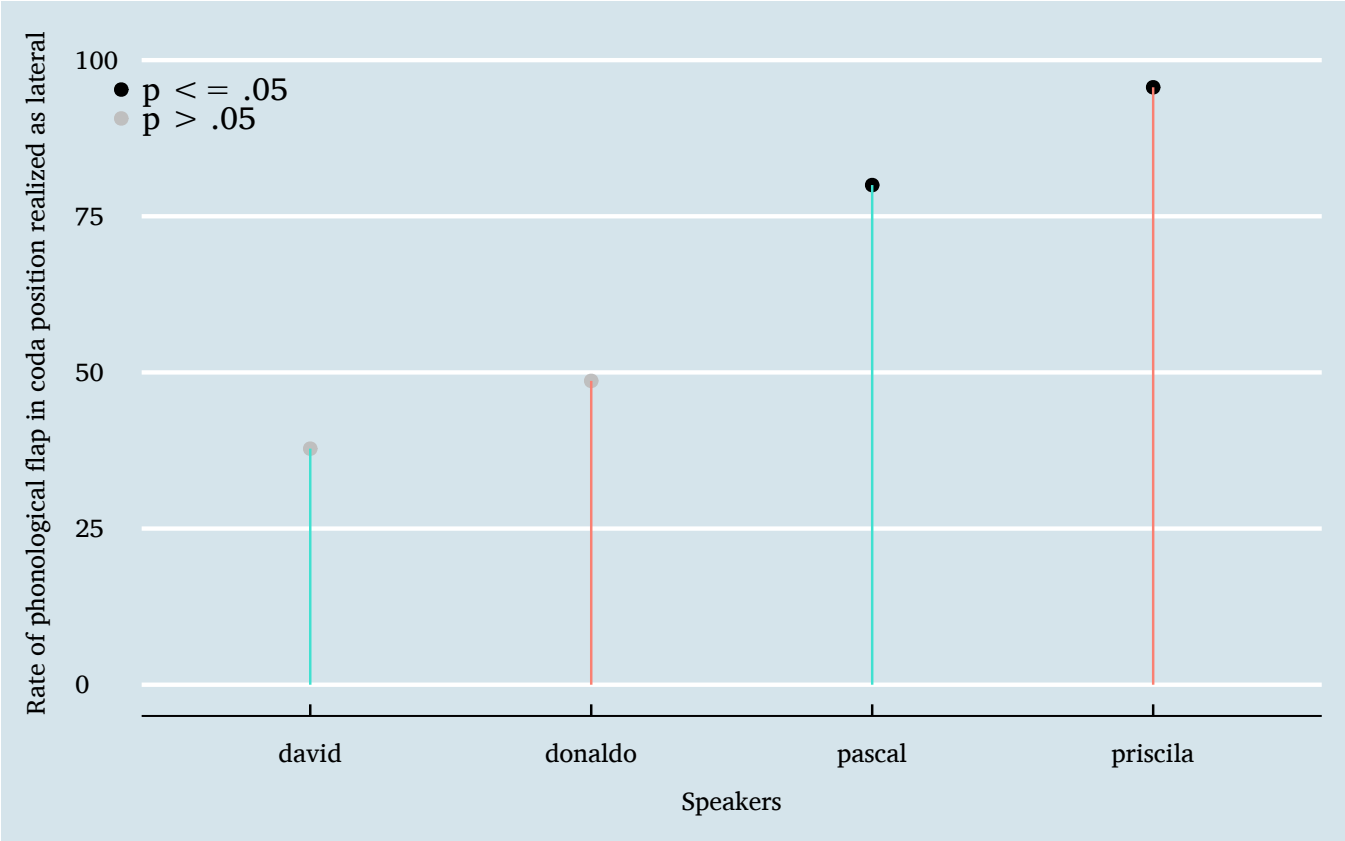

Figure 1: Comparison of Phonological Flap Neutralization Rates in Coda Position among Adult and Child Arrival Spanish Speakers from Puerto Rico and the Dominican Republic